The next major population group in India's great plains that finds a mention in historical records are the Vedic cultures, located around the *sapta sindhu* or the land of seven rivers identified with the tributaries of the Indus—the name which itself, and subsequently 'India', 'Hindu', and 'Hindustan', are derived from the root word 'sindhu', meaning river. The geographical location of the Indo-Aryans, as the Vedic people are referred to, is noted to have shifted eastwards over time. There are references to migrations into the Gangetic plains in the *Satapatha Brahmana*, a Vedic text. For instance, King Videgha Mathava is said to have led his people eastwards as far as the Gandak River, along the Himalayan foothills.[16] This could have been along the *uttarapatha* or the northern route described in ancient Indian texts, linking the Ganga and Yamuna river systems and Punjab to central Asia.[17]

The Indo-Aryans are usually considered to be pastoralists. They used the horse, mostly imported from outside the subcontinent, for equestrian activities, greatly increasing the speed of movement within the subcontinent. They spoke languages such as Sanskrit which would later be classified under the Indo-European category. Their most famous literary compositions are the Ramayana and Mahabharata, two classic epics that have deep resonance even today. Significantly, both the epics had exile and return as the central themes, conveying the circularity of migration.

Another important offshoot of the Vedic culture with a persistent legacy was a unique social structure called the varna or caste system. It divided society into four varnas: the brahmin (priest), kshatriya (warrior), vaishya (trader) and shudra (labourer), and an additional group of the outcastes or the untouchables. The system specified not only division but also hierarchy in terms of ritual status. The caste system may not have crystallized strongly in the first millennium BCE, and the numerous jatis or sub-castes may have emerged much later, but it did lay the foundations for strict endogamy or marriage within groups. Genetic studies show that around this time, there was a demographic transformation from a region where 'major population mixture was common to one in which mixture even between closely related groups became rare because of a shift to endogamy'.[18] It is a